6 DEVOTIONALS ON HABAKKUK

Yet I Will Rejoice

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How to use this booklet

1. Set aside about 15 to 20 minutes for each day, ideally somewhere quiet.
2. Read the Scripture passage first, slowly – aloud, if you can. It stands at the start of each devotional.
3. "Digging Deeper" takes you into the context and the language of the original text. "Living It Out" asks what it means for you.
4. Take your time with the questions. You may want to write your answers down.
5. Close with the prayer – and with your own words.

Yet I Will Rejoice
6 devotionals on Habakkuk

Scripture: own translation from the Hebrew (Masoretic Text) by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé. Verse numbers follow the Hebrew text.

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Read online: https://hannesnortje.github.io/devotionals/habakuk/en/

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DAY 1

When Heaven Feels Silent

SCRIPTURE
Habakkuk 1:1–4

1 The oracle that Habakkuk the prophet saw.

2 How long, LORD, shall I cry for help,
and you do not hear?
I cry out to you, "Violence!"
and you do not save.
3 Why do you make me see wickedness,
and why do you look on misery?
Destruction and violence are before me;
there is strife, and contention rises up.
4 Therefore instruction grows numb,
and justice never comes forth.
For the wicked surrounds the righteous;
therefore justice comes forth twisted.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Welcome to this six-day journey through the book of **Habakkuk**. Most prophets spoke to the people on God's behalf; Habakkuk turns the roles around and speaks to God on behalf of the people. His book takes us on a raw, honest journey from painful questions and confusion ("*How long, LORD, shall I cry for help, and you do not hear?*" – 1:2) to one of the most powerful confessions of unshakeable faith in all of Scripture ("*yet I will exult in the LORD, I will rejoice in the God of my salvation*" – 3:18). We will spread the three chapters over six days, so that we can look closely at every complaint, every answer from the Lord, and the closing song of prayer.

To understand Habakkuk's raw emotion, we need to go back to Judah at the end of the seventh century BC, probably during the dark reign of King Jehoiakim (about 609–598 BC; the book itself names no king). The godly King Josiah, who had led a great spiritual revival and reform, had died tragically at Megiddo (609 BC). Almost overnight Judah slid back into corruption, idolatry, social injustice and political violence. The rich exploited the poor, the courts were bribed, and God's law (the *torah*) was openly despised.

In the middle of this moral collapse stands Habakkuk. We know almost nothing of his personal history, except that he is called "the prophet" (which may mean he was an official temple prophet or a liturgical singer, as chapter 3 suggests). But his name itself carries a deep message.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Habakkuk (*Chavaqquq* – חֲבַקּוּק):** The name is often linked with the Hebrew root *chavaq*, which means "**to embrace**" or "**to hold tight**" (others connect it with an Akkadian plant name). Martin Luther put it memorably: Habakkuk is someone who takes his people in his arms, comforts them and embraces them. We may add: at the same time he clings to God in prayer and wrestles with him until he receives an answer.
- **Oracle (*hammassa'* – הַמַּשָּׂא):** Verse 1 uses the word *massa'*. It comes from the verb *nasa'* ("lift, carry") and can mean "**a burden**" – a heavy load. The message Habakkuk receives is no light theoretical philosophy; it is a crushing weight on his soul, because he feels the pain of the world and the holiness of God at the same time.
- **Cry for help (*shiwwa'ti* – *שִׁוַּעְתִּי*) and cry out (*ez'aq* – *אֶזְעַק*): *In verse 2 Habakkuk uses two different verbs for prayer. Shiwwa' is the persistent cry for help of someone in distress; za'aq* is the loud cry of someone in danger. And in that cry he utters one specific word:*** chamas*** – חָמָס ("Violence!" – cruelty, bloodshed and injustice).

- **Grows numb (*tafug* – תָּפוּג):** When verse 4 says "*Therefore instruction grows numb*", the Hebrew uses the verb *pug*: to grow cold, limp, without feeling. God's good instruction (*torah* – תּוֹרָה, his law) has lost its power in society because no one applies it any more; justice comes out of the court gates *me'uqqal* – מְעֻקָּל (crooked, bent and warped – "twisted").

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Lament is a legitimate form of worship:** Habakkuk shows that true faith does not mean smiling and pretending everything is fine while the world burns. He does not hide his frustration behind pious phrases. He takes his pain **to** God, not away from God. Doubt that talks to God is, in fact, deep faith.
2. **The tension between God's character and our reality:** Habakkuk's crisis arises precisely *because* he believes in a good, righteous and almighty God. If God were indifferent or weak, Habakkuk would not ask "Why?" It is our very conviction of God's goodness that sometimes makes the silence of heaven so hard to understand.
3. **Spiritual sensitivity brings holy unrest:** Many people in Judah had simply adapted to the corrupt culture or grown numb. Habakkuk refuses to get used to sin and injustice. His prayer shows that a heart that lives close to God hurts over the things that break God's heart.

Living It Out

We live today in a world that often looks just like Jehoiakim's Judah. When we open the news or look around us, we see *chamas* (violence), corruption that goes unpunished, and righteous people oppressed while the wicked seem to flourish. But it touches our personal lives too: perhaps you have been praying for months or years about a broken relationship, a health crisis, financial injustice, or the spiritual decline of someone you love – and it feels as if your prayers bounce off the ceiling.

How do we respond when God seems silent? Usually we fall into one of two traps:

- **Cynicism and coldness:** We let our hearts go numb (*pug*), stop praying, and decide that God either does not care or cannot intervene.
- **False piety:** We suppress our honest questions because we think it is "sin" to ask God *why* or *how long*. We wear a Sunday mask while we bleed inside.

Habakkuk shows us a third, healthy way: **wrestling in prayer**. He gives us permission to stand raw and honest before the throne of grace. God is not afraid of your hard questions. He prefers your honest tears and cries to your polished, empty religious words. To cling to God in the darkness, as Habakkuk did, is the first step towards spiritual breakthrough.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Is there a specific situation in your life or in our society where you are crying out right now, "*How long*, LORD?" Have you put that frustration honestly into words before God, or are you trying to hide it?
- Where in your life are you in danger of growing spiritually "cold or numb" (*pug*) because you are tired of waiting for change?
- What is the difference between complaining *about* God to other people and bringing your complaint *directly* to God in prayer?

Prayer

> *Almighty and holy Father, today I come to you without masks or pretence. Like Habakkuk I must confess that there are things in my life and in the world around me that I simply do not understand. I see brokenness, injustice and pain, and sometimes it feels as if the heavens are bronze when I call. Lord, keep my heart from growing cold, cynical or numb.*

Thank you that you are a Father with whom I am welcome, raw questions, tears and all. I do not understand why you sometimes wait, but today I choose to bring my confusion to you instead of turning away from you.

Give me the courage to cling to you in the dark, knowing that you are not deaf to my prayers. Hear my cry, O Lord, and renew my trust in your righteous character. Amen.

DAY 2

An Unexpected and Shocking Answer

SCRIPTURE

Habakkuk 1:5–11

5 See among the nations, and look;
be astonished – be astounded!
For I am doing a work in your days
that you would not believe if it were told.
6 For look, I am raising up the Chaldeans,
that bitter and impetuous nation,
who march across the breadth of the earth
to take possession of dwellings that are not their own.
7 Terrible and dreadful is he;
from himself come forth his justice and his dignity.
8 His horses are swifter than leopards
and fiercer than wolves at evening.
His horsemen gallop on,
his horsemen come from far away;
they fly like a vulture that hurries to devour.
9 All of them come for violence;
the set of their faces is forward,
and he gathers captives like sand.
10 He mocks at kings,
and rulers are a joke to him.
He laughs at every fortress;
he heaps up dust and captures it.
11 Then he sweeps on like the wind and passes by,
and he becomes guilty –
he whose strength is his god.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

On Day 1 Habakkuk accused God of silence and inaction. He thought the Lord was looking the other way while Judah rotted in corruption. But in verse 5 God breaks the silence – and his answer takes Habakkuk's breath away. God had not been passive at all; behind the scenes he was already orchestrating a world-historical shift that no one in Judah saw coming.

Historical and military background: To feel the shock of verse 6 we need to look at the political map of the late seventh century BC. For centuries the Assyrian Empire had been the dominant superpower of the ancient Near East, with Egypt as the other great power. The **Chaldeans** (the Neo-Babylonian Empire under Nabopolassar, who became king of Babylon in 626 BC, and his son, crown prince Nebuchadnezzar) had long been only a subordinate group. But within two decades Babylon, together with the Medes, crushed Assyria (Nineveh fell in 612 BC) and defeated the Egyptian army at the famous Battle of Carchemish (605 BC).

For a citizen of Jerusalem the thought that God would use this ruthless, pagan war machine to discipline his own covenant people was simply unthinkable. God describes them in terrifying poetic images: swifter than leopards, fiercer than wolves at evening hunting in the dark, and like a vulture swooping on its prey. They mock fortified cities by simply piling up earthen ramps against the walls and overrunning them (*"he heaps up dust and captures it"*).

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Be astonished – be astounded! (*wehittammehu tamahu* – וְהִתַּמְּהוּ תְּמָהוּ):** God doubles the Hebrew verb *tamah*. It does not mean being mildly surprised, but being paralysed with shock, bewilderment and disbelief. The New Testament (Acts 13:41) quotes this very verse to warn people not to overlook God's saving work in Christ because of their own prejudices.

- **I am raising up (*meqim* – מֵקִים):** A participle of the verb *qum* ("rise") in its causative form: "make rise, raise up". Nebuchadnezzar thought he was building his own empire, but the Hebrew makes it crystal clear: it is **YHWH** who raises the Babylonians onto the world stage.
- **Bitter and impetuous (*hammar wehannimhar* – הַמַּר וְהַנִּמְהָר):** A powerful play on words and sounds in the Hebrew. *Mar* means bitter, cruel, merciless; *nimhar* means hasty, reckless, unstoppable.
- **From himself come forth his justice (*mimmennu mishpato* – מִמֶּנּוּ מִשְׁפָּטוֹ, v. 7):** The Babylonians recognise no higher moral law and no divine authority. They are a law to themselves; they decide right and wrong on the basis of sheer military power.
- **He whose strength is his god (v. 11):** Verse 11 says that he sweeps on like the wind *"and he becomes guilty"* (*we'ashem* – וְאָשֵׁם), because they worship their own abilities and military success as their idol.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's silence never means God's absence:** While Habakkuk thought God was doing nothing (1:2), God says: *"For I am doing a work in your days"* (1:5). God often works on a large scale, beyond our immediate field of vision.
2. **God is sovereign over all nations, even the godless:** The Lord is not merely a local tribal god of Israel; he rules the whole of world history. He can use even broken, secular or hostile powers as instruments in his hand to achieve his purposes and to shake his people awake.
3. **God's answers rarely fit our boxes:** Habakkuk had prayed for a tidy, internal spiritual revival in Judah. God answers with a Babylonian invasion. When we pray that God would root out evil and compromise in our lives, he sometimes uses radical and painful pruning shears we would never have chosen ourselves.

4. **Human pride carries the seed of its own downfall:** Although God uses the Chaldeans, he does not approve of their cruelty. Verse 11 ends on a decisive note: by making his own strength a god, *"he becomes guilty"*. Their arrogance will in the end be judged by the same sovereign God.

Living It Out

This passage jolts us out of our comfort zone. We like a predictable God – a God who answers our prayers exactly according to the script we have written for him. We ask for patience and expect a warm feeling of peace; instead God brings a difficult situation or a trying person across our path who exposes our impatience. We pray that God would purify our church or our family, and then he shakes our false securities until only he is left.

Sometimes God's answer to our prayers at first brings *more* questions and discomfort than the original problem! When the foundations of our world shake – through economic uncertainty, political upheaval or personal crises – we easily get stuck in fear of the "Chaldeans" of our time. We stare ourselves blind at the power of the problem, the injustice of people, or the speed at which things spin out of control.

Habakkuk 1:5–11 calls us to look wider: *"See among the nations, and look!"* Even when earthly powers or the storms of life seem to make their own laws and flatten everything before them, they still stand under the sovereign rule of the Creator. And just as with the Babylonians, we must examine our own hearts: where do we rely on our own cleverness, our bank account or our own control, so that our own strength becomes our god?

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Has God ever answered a prayer in your life in a way that caught you completely off guard – something that first looked like a disaster but later turned out to be his way of shaping or rescuing you?

- Which "Chaldeans" (threats, crises or powers beyond your control) frighten you at the moment? How does it change your perspective to know that nothing on earth can rise up unless God allows it within his greater purpose?
- In verses 7 and 11 we read of one from whom *"come forth his justice and his dignity"* and *"whose strength is his god"*. In which areas of your daily life do you live as if your own strength and abilities were enough, without depending on the Lord?

Prayer

> *Sovereign Lord, King over the nations and over my life, today I bow in wonder before your greatness. Forgive me for so often trying to fit you into a small, predictable box, and for thinking you are silent just because I cannot see what you are doing. Sometimes your ways frighten me, Lord, for your thoughts are higher than my thoughts.*
>
> *When the storms of this world rush at me like an impetuous army, keep me from staring in panic at the threat. Open the eyes of my heart to see that your hand stays on the helm even in the midst of chaos.*
>
> *Today I also confess every place in my own heart where I have made an idol of my own strength, my own plans and my own control. Break my self-willed pride and teach me to trust you, even when your answers leave me utterly astounded. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

DAY 3

At the Guard Post of Faith

SCRIPTURE

Habakkuk 1:12 – 2:1

12 Are you not from of old, LORD,
my God, my Holy One?
We will not die.
LORD, you have appointed him for judgment;
O Rock, you have established him to reprove.
13 Your eyes are too pure to see evil,
and you cannot look on misery.
Why do you look on the treacherous
and keep silent when the wicked swallows up
one more righteous than he?
14 You make people like the fish of the sea,
like crawling things that have no ruler.
15 He brings them all up with a hook,
he drags them away in his net
and gathers them in his dragnet;
so he is glad and rejoices.
16 Therefore he sacrifices to his net
and burns incense to his dragnet,
for through them his portion is fat
and his food is rich.
17 Is he then to keep emptying his net
and go on killing nations without sparing?
1 I will stand at my guard post
and take my place on the rampart;
I will watch to see what he will say to me
and what I shall answer concerning my reproof.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

God's answer on Day 2 plunged Habakkuk into an even deeper theological crisis. In his first complaint he wrestled with God's apparent *silence* about the sin in Judah; now he wrestles with God's *method*. How can a spotless, righteous God use a nation as cruel and idolatrous as Babylon to punish a people (Judah) who, for all their faults, are at least less corrupt than the Chaldeans? To Habakkuk the cure feels worse than the disease!

And yet we see a huge shift in how Habakkuk approaches his second complaint. Before he asks his new "Why?", he first anchors himself in who God is. He does not move from his doubt towards God; he moves from God's eternal character towards his doubt. Then he paints the Babylonian empire as an unscrupulous fisherman who scoops up human lives like cheap fish in a dragnet and then worships his own net (his war machine and economic prosperity) as a god. Having poured out his heart, Habakkuk climbs the watchtower on the city wall to wait patiently for God's answer.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **O Rock (*tsur* – צוּר):** In verse 12 Habakkuk calls God *Tsur* (Rock) – the only time in his book. While the Babylonians sweep over the earth like a storm and everything around Habakkuk totters, he holds on to God as the immovable rock face and refuge (compare Deuteronomy 32:4).
- **From of old (*miqqedem* – מִקֶּדֶם):** For Habakkuk this means: from eternity. Babylon rose yesterday and will fall again tomorrow, but YHWH exists before all time and beyond every crisis.
- **Net and dragnet (*chermo* – חֶרְמוֹ and *mikhmarto* – מִכְמַרְתּוֹ):** Verses 15–16 speak of fishing nets. Ancient Mesopotamian images (such as the Sumerian "Stele of the Vultures", long before Habakkuk's time) show a god or king holding his defeated enemies in a huge net – a familiar pic-

ture of victory and power. Habakkuk takes up the same image: the Babylonians virtually worship their military technology and their profits (their *fat portion*) – the fisherman *"burns incense to his dragnet"*.

- **Guard post (*mishmarti* – מִשְׁמַרְתִּי) and rampart (*matsor* – מָצוֹר):** In 2:1 Habakkuk uses military language for his prayer life. A sentry on a city wall (*matsor* – fortification, rampart) must not fall asleep; he scans the horizon with focused expectation.
- **Reproof (*tokhachti* – תוֹכַחְתִּי):** At the end of 2:1 Habakkuk expects God to answer his argument. The word *tokhachat* can mean his own complaint (his "reproof" of God), but it also means "correction" or "rebuke" – the same root as in 1:12, where God has established the Chaldean *"to reprove"* (*lehokhiach* – לְהוֹכִיחַ). Habakkuk is humble enough to know that his own perspective may need to be corrected by God.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Start with what you know about God before you ask about what you do not understand:** In verses 12–13 Habakkuk confesses five non-negotiable truths about God: he is eternal (*from of old*), personal (*my God*), set apart from sin (*my Holy One*), sovereign and unshakeable (*Rock*), and morally spotless (*"Your eyes are too pure to see evil"*). That is why he can cry out with certainty: *"We will not die."* God's covenant people will be disciplined, but never wiped out.
2. **Dehumanising others is an abomination to God:** When the powerful treat people merely *"like the fish of the sea"* or *"like crawling things"* (verse 14) – as mere numbers, pawns or commodities to increase their own wealth and "fat portion" – it runs directly against the God who created human beings in his image.
3. **Materialism and technology easily become modern idols:** The Chaldeans did not only worship little wooden figures; they burned incense to their "net" (their business, their weapons, the methods that

brought them prosperity). Wherever we place our security and identity in our "net" (our career, skill or income), we commit the same idolatry.

4. **True prayer is a two-way conversation that requires silence and waiting:** Habakkuk does not simply fire his complaints into the air and walk away. In 2:1 he takes his stand at his guard post. He makes room for silence, ready to listen and to let God's Word correct his own heart.

Living It Out

When a crisis hits and our prayers seem to be answered in a way that only causes more pain, our first instinct is to question everything. We let our confusing *circumstances* define God's *character* for us. Habakkuk teaches us a life-saving spiritual habit: **build a theological framework around your pain.** Before you ask your next "Why?", first say out loud who God is. Remind your soul that he is your Rock (*Tsur*) and that his eyes are too pure to approve of injustice, even if his timing makes no sense to you right now.

Habakkuk 2:1 also challenges our hurried, modern prayer life. We often treat prayer like a fast-food drive-through: we place our order (or our list of complaints) at the first window and race straight on into our busy day without waiting for the answer. To say with Habakkuk, *"I will stand at my guard post"*, means deliberately stepping back from the noise of life, opening the Scriptures and waiting with an open, teachable spirit. And notice Habakkuk's attitude: he is willing to be *corrected* by God. Sometimes God does not change our situation at once, because he first wants to change our perspective up on the watchtower.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- When you go through a deep disappointment, which of God's attributes in verses 12–13 (his eternity, his holiness, his faithfulness as Rock, or his purity) do you find hardest to hold on to? Why?

- Look at verse 16, where the enemy is described: *"Therefore he sacrifices to his net"* – because it gives him a rich life. Which "nets" in your life – your work, your qualifications, your savings or your skills – are receiving the honour and trust that belong to God alone?
- What does your personal "guard post" (2:1) look like? Do you make time in your quiet time simply to become still and listen to what the Holy Spirit wants to say back to your heart through his Word – or do you do all the talking?

Prayer

> *Eternal Lord, my God and my Holy One, today I choose to set my feet on you as my unshakeable Rock. When what happens in my life and in the world seems unjust and confusing to me, I thank you that your character never changes. You are from of old, and your eyes are too pure to approve of evil.*
>
> *Keep my heart from ever seeing people as a mere means to an end, or from "sacrificing to my own net" like the world, by trusting in my own skill and prosperity.*
>
> *Lord, today I climb the guard post of faith. I quiet my own restless thoughts before you. Speak to my spirit through your Word, and where my own view is crooked or short-sighted, correct me in your love. I wait for you, my Rock and my Redeemer. Amen.*

DAY 4

The Righteous Will Live by Faith

SCRIPTURE
Habakkuk 2:2–5

2 Then the LORD answered me and said:

Write down the vision
and make it plain on the tablets,
so that whoever reads it may run.
3 For the vision is still for the appointed time;
it pants toward the end, and it will not deceive.
If it lingers, wait for it,
for it will surely come; it will not delay.
4 Look, he is puffed up – his soul is not upright within him;
but the righteous will live by his faithfulness.
5 And moreover, wine is treacherous;
an arrogant man does not stay at home.
He opens his throat wide like the grave;
he is like death and is never sated.
He gathers to himself all the nations
and assembles to himself all the peoples.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

While Habakkuk stands at his guard post (2:1), God's voice breaks through the silence once more. This time the LORD does not give a spoken answer for the prophet alone; he gives a lasting revelation that is to be written plainly on tablets for every generation that would come after. Here we stand on the theological summit of the whole book of Habakkuk. Verse 4b (*"but the righteous will live by his faithfulness"*) is one of the most influential

sentences in the whole Bible – the cornerstone on which the apostle Paul built his gospel in Romans and Galatians, and the spark that lit the Protestant Reformation.

In the ancient Near East, important royal decrees were set out in large, clear script on clay tablets or stone stelae and erected in public places. The phrase *"so that whoever reads it may run"* (v. 2) is doubly rich: the letters must be so large and clear that they can be read at a glance, and the messenger (herald) who has read them can at once run off to spread the good news of God's final victory throughout the land.

In verse 5 God uses a sharp image: *"wine is treacherous"*. Daniel 5, with Belshazzar's feast, and later Greek historians tell of a feast on the night Babylon fell. Just as wine deceives you – it makes you feel invincible while in fact it makes you stumble – so Babylon's drunkenness with power and its greed, with a throat as insatiable as *Sheol* (the grave), sealed its own downfall. Notice the contrast too: the Hebrew word for "treacherous" (*boged*, 2:5; "the treacherous", 1:13) means acting treacherously, breaking faith – and so it stands over against the faithfulness of the righteous (2:4).

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Appointed time (*mo'ed* – מוֹעֵד):** In verse 3 God says the vision is for the *mo'ed* – a specific, fixed time on God's calendar. History does not drift aimlessly; God has already set the exact hour at which evil will be stopped.
- **It pants toward the end (*weyafeach laqqets* – וְיָפֵחַ לַקֵּץ):** Literally, "it pants toward the end". Like an athlete racing for the finishing line, breathing hard, God's promise moves unstoppably forward – even when to the human eye it seems to stand still.
- **Puffed up (*'uppelah* – עֻפְּלָה):** In verse 4 the proud one (probably the Babylonian) is described as *'uppelah* – puffed up, swollen. It is the picture of a swelling, of a false self-importance that refuses to bow before God.

- **Faithfulness / faith (*'emunah* – אֱמוּנָה):** The Hebrew word in verse 4 is *'emunah*, from the root *'aman* (from which our word "Amen" comes). It means **steadfastness, reliability, persevering loyalty and unshakeable trust**. In Exodus 17:12 we read that Moses' hands remained *'emunah* (firm and steady) during the battle. That is why our translation reads "*by his faithfulness*": it is a trust that holds on and stays faithful. The same root stands in 1:5, where God says: "*that you would not believe if it were told*" (lo *ta'aminu* – לֹא תַאֲמִינוּ, from *he'emin*, "believe"). In Hebrew, believing and being faithful belong to one family of words. The ancient Greek translation (the Septuagint) reads: "the righteous will live by **my** faithfulness" – God's faithfulness. Paul quotes the verse in Romans 1:17 and Galatians 3:11 as "The righteous will live by faith", and Hebrews 10:38 reads: "*but my righteous one will live by faith*". The New Testament therefore reads *'emunah* as faith – and the word holds that meaning too, because faithfulness in Habakkuk is trust that holds on: a faith that stays faithful. True faith in Habakkuk is not a quick mental assent; it is a lifelong, reliable clinging to God's promises in the middle of the fiery trial.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's promises are delayed, but never cancelled:** Verse 3 strikes a wonderful balance: "*If it lingers, wait for it, for it will surely come*". From our human point of view God's promises often seem delayed ("*if it lingers*"), but from God's point of view they are never late ("*it will not delay*"). The waiting period is not empty time; it is the school in which faith is formed.
2. **Two ways of living in a broken world:** Verse 4 divides the whole of humanity into two camps. There is the person with the "puffed-up soul" who leans on his own pride, power and visible success – and he goes under. And there is the "righteous" one who knows he cannot save himself, and therefore lives by *'emunah* (trusting faith in God).

3. **The threefold power of Habakkuk 2:4 in the New Testament:** This single verse is so rich that the New Testament quotes it three times, each time with a different emphasis: - **Romans 1:17** stresses "**the righteous**" – how does a person become righteous before God? Only through faith in Christ. - **Galatians 3:11** stresses "**will live**" – how do we receive and keep spiritual life? Not by works of the law, but by faith. - **Hebrews 10:38** stresses "**by faith**" – how does a believer survive and persevere when persecution and hardship go on and on? By steadfast, waiting trust (*'emunah*).
4. **Pride and greed are addictive and self-destructive:** Just as death never says, "Now I have swallowed enough people" (v. 5), so earthly power, money and recognition can never satisfy the human soul. They promise freedom, but deliver only a deeper emptiness.

Living It Out

We live in a culture of instant gratification. If a web page takes more than three seconds to load, we get frustrated. So when God places us in a season of "waiting" – when the healing, the breakthrough, the restoring of justice or the answer to prayer drags on for months or years – we are tempted to think that God's promise has "deceived" us (v. 3).

Habakkuk 2:2–5 calls us back to the basic rhythm of the kingdom: "**If it lingers, wait for it.**" But notice *how* we are to wait. We do not wait passively with folded hands; we *live* by faith while we wait. To live by *'emunah* means that today – before your circumstances have changed by a single millimetre – you choose to act as if God's Word is true. While the world around you "puffs up" its soul with self-promotion, anxious control and an insatiable chase after more, the righteous rest in the knowledge that the Judge of the universe has already set the appointed time (*mo'ed*) for all injustice.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- In which area of your life are you feeling the tension of verse 3 right now: "*If it lingers, wait for it*"? How has this time of waiting affected your relationship with the Lord so far – has it driven you closer to him or left you discouraged?
- God commands Habakkuk to write down the vision and make it plain on the tablets, so that it will not be forgotten in the dark days to come. Which specific promises from God's Word, or lessons from your past, do you need to "write down" today to carry you through your present storm?
- Looking honestly at the contrast in verse 4: where in your daily decisions are you operating with a "puffed-up soul" (trust in your own control, pride and visible results) instead of simple, steadfast *'emunah* (trust in God's character)?

Prayer

Faithful Father, God of the appointed time, I bow before you today with a heart that often grows weary of waiting. You know the questions I carry and the things I have been praying for so long. Thank you for the unshakeable promise in your Word that your vision will not deceive and that you are never too late.

Lord, heal my soul of every form of pride and self-sufficiency. Keep me from the treacherous wine of this world that makes me think more possessions, more recognition or more human control will ever satisfy me. Write your truth deep on the tablets of my heart today: that the righteous will live by faith.

Give me that Hebrew 'emunah – a steadfast, reliable and persevering trust in Jesus Christ, my Righteousness and my Life. I choose to wait for you, even when it lingers, because I know it will surely come. Amen.

DAY 5

Five Woes and the Glory of the LORD

SCRIPTURE

Habakkuk 2:6–20

6 Will not all of these take up a taunt against him,
a mocking song, riddles about him, and say:
Woe to the one who heaps up what is not his own –
how long? –
and loads himself heavy with pledges!
7 Will not those who bite you rise up suddenly,
and those who make you tremble wake up,
and you will become plunder for them?
8 Because you have plundered many nations,
all who are left of the peoples will plunder you,
because of human blood and violence to the land,
to the city and all who live in it.
9 Woe to the one who gains evil gain for his house,
to set his nest on high,
to be snatched from the grip of evil!
10 You have counselled shame for your house
by cutting off many peoples,
and you are sinning against your own life.
11 For a stone from the wall will cry out,
and a rafter from the woodwork will answer it.
12 Woe to the one who builds a town with blood
and founds a city on injustice!
13 Look, is it not from the LORD of hosts
that peoples toil only for the fire
and nations weary themselves for nothing?
14 For the earth will be filled
with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD,
as the waters cover the sea.
15 Woe to the one who makes his neighbour drink,
mixing in your wrath and making him drunk as well,
in order to look on their nakedness!
16 You are sated with disgrace instead of glory.
Drink, you too, and show your foreskin!

The cup in the LORD's right hand will come around to you,
and utter disgrace will come upon your glory.
17 For the violence done to Lebanon will cover you,
and the destruction of the beasts that terrified them,
because of human blood and violence to the land,
to the city and all who live in it.
18 What use is a carved image,
that its maker has carved it,
a cast image and a teacher of lies?
For its maker trusts in what he himself has formed
when he makes mute idols.
19 Woe to the one who says to wood, "Wake up!"
"Awake!" to a silent stone.
Can it teach?
Look, it is overlaid with gold and silver,
and there is no breath at all inside it.
20 But the LORD is in his holy temple –
silence before him, all the earth!

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Having declared in verse 4 that Babylon's proud, "puffed-up" soul will perish while the righteous will live by his faithfulness, God now spells out in verses 6–20 exactly *why* and *how* this violent world empire will fall. God puts a forward-looking taunt-song into the mouths of the very peoples oppressed by the Chaldeans. The passage is built around **five "Woes"** (*hoy* in Hebrew) – each of about three verses – which lay bare, right down to the bone, the moral rot and false foundations of the Babylonian empire.

King Nebuchadnezzar and his successors turned Babylon into one of the architectural wonders of the ancient world, complete with massive double city walls, the Ishtar Gate and huge temples. But how was this splendid city paid for? By ruthless plunder, slave labour, extortion from

smaller nations, and even the large-scale felling and destruction of Lebanon's famous cedar forests (verse 17). God pulls back the curtain on Babylon's apparent glory and shows that its whole empire was built on stolen goods and human blood.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Woe! (*hoy* – הוֹי):** This cry occurs five times (verses 6, 9, 12, 15, 19). In prophetic literature *hoy* combines a funeral lament ("Alas, how tragic!") with a divine announcement of judgement ("Beware, the end is coming!"). God, as it were, is already holding Babylon's funeral while it still stands at the height of its power.
- **Pledges (*'avtit* – עַבְטִיט):** In verse 6 a rare Hebrew word is used (only here in the Bible) meaning "pledges, IOUs" – goods obtained through usury. Older translations read it as two words, *'av tit*, "a thick layer of mud or clay". The picture is apt: what Babylon thinks are golden treasures is in reality only a heavy load of mud that will make it sink.
- **Glory (*kavod* – כָּבוֹד):** In verse 14 we read of the *kavod* of the LORD. The root means "to be heavy, weighty"; its opposite, *qalon* ("disgrace", v. 16), comes from "to be light". While Babylon's power will vanish like a light mist – "*You are sated with disgrace instead of glory*" (v. 16) – the true "weight" and majesty of God will finally flood the whole earth.
- **Mute idols (*elilim illemim* – אֱלִילִים אִלְּמִים):** In verse 18 Habakkuk uses a sharp Hebrew wordplay. *Elilim* means "worthless little things / idols" (it calls to mind *Elohim*, God), and *illemim* means "mute, speechless". People worship shiny, dead images with "*no breath at all inside*" them (*ruach*, v. 19).
- **Silence! (*has* – הַס):** In verse 20 the chapter closes with the Hebrew sound-word *has!* – just like our "hush!" or "shh!". In contrast to the mute idols that *cannot* speak, the living God in his temple brings the whole noisy, proud world to reverent silence.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The woe against greed and theft (vv. 6–8):** *The law of divine retribution (lex talionis).* Babylon grew rich by exploitation, but its victims will suddenly rise up like creditors and strip it bare. Dishonest gain is never a blessing; it is a time bomb.

2. **The woe against false security and pride (vv. 9–11):** *No human fortress is high enough to escape God's judgement.* They wanted "*to set his nest on high*" (like an eagle, out of reach of danger) by trampling on others. But even if every human witness is silenced, the stones in the walls and the rafters of their palaces will cry out as witnesses against their injustice (compare Luke 19:40).

3. **The woe against violence and bloodshed (vv. 12–14):** *All human empires built without God end in the fire.* Verse 13 shows the futility of godless ambition: peoples wear themselves out building empires that in the end are only firewood for history. Why? Because God's final goal for creation is not Babylon's glory, but this: "*For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the* LORD" (v. 14).

4. **The woe against exploitation and dehumanisation (vv. 15–17):** *Whoever humiliates others will himself be humiliated by God.* Babylon made neighbouring nations politically and militarily "drunk" with false treaties and violence, to leave them defenceless and rob them of their dignity ("nakedness"), and even laid waste to nature (Lebanon's forests and animals). That is why "*the cup in the* LORD*'s right hand*" (the cup of wrath) will come around to it, so that its apparent glory is covered with disgrace.

5. **The woe against idolatry (vv. 18–20):** *The folly of man-made gods over against the majesty of the living God.* The root of all the preceding social evils (greed, pride, violence and cruelty) is idolatry (v. 18). When people worship the work of their own hands, they lose their moral compass. But verse 20 thunders out the final truth: idols are dead, but **the LORD is in his holy temple!**

Living It Out

When we look at these five "Woes", it is easy simply to point a finger at the ancient Babylonians or at corrupt world leaders. But the Spirit of God also holds this text up like a mirror to our own modern hearts. We live in a consumer culture still driven by the same five temptations: the urge always to heap up more (v. 6); the attempt to "set our nest on high" through financial security, so that no crisis can touch us (v. 9); the willingness to walk over other people to build our own career or "city" (v. 12); the manipulation or humiliation of others for our own advantage (v. 15); and trust in "mute idols" overlaid with gold and silver – status, technology and possessions with no spiritual life inside them (v. 19).

Yet Habakkuk 2:6–20 also gives two indescribable anchors of comfort to the believer who is discouraged today about the state of the world:

- **First, verse 14:** The world will not end in Babylonian chaos. History is moving unstoppably towards the day when the knowledge of the glory of the LORD will cover every square centimetre of the earth, *"as the waters cover the sea"*. Your labour in the Lord is never in vain, because you are building his eternal kingdom, not something destined "for the fire".
- **Second, verse 20:** When politics rages, the economy totters and injustice seems overwhelming, hear the voice that says: *"silence before him, all the earth!"* God's throne is not vacant. He is in his holy temple, fully in control. Where in chapter 1 Habakkuk asked why God *keeps silent* (1:13), chapter 2 ends with Habakkuk himself falling *silent* in reverent worship before God's almighty power.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Verse 9 warns against the attempt *"to set his nest on high, to be snatched from the grip of evil"*. Where are you currently looking for your deepest sense of safety and invulnerability – in your bank account, your insurance and your own planning, or in the presence of the Lord?

- Verse 13 speaks of peoples who "*toil only for the fire*" and "*weary themselves for nothing*". Looking at where most of your time, energy and emotion went this past month: how much of it is building things of eternal value (v. 14), and how much of it is merely earthly chasing that will burn up?
- What does it mean for you in practice to apply verse 20 today – to bring your own inner noise, anxiety and complaints to a standstill ("*silence before him*"), because you know the LORD is in his holy temple?

Prayer

> *Holy and almighty* LORD *of hosts, today I become silent before you. I bow in deep reverence before your throne, for you alone are God, and you are in your holy temple. Lord, search my heart in the light of your Word. Keep me from ever seeking my security in building my own high nest, or from trusting in the shiny, mute idols of this age that have no life inside them.*
>
> *Forgive me for the times I wear myself out for things that are nothing and will in the end be consumed by the fire. Thank you for the wonderful assurance that no injustice, exploitation or violence will have the last word on this earth. Let my heart take courage today from your promise that the earth will be filled with the knowledge of your glory, as the waters cover the sea.*
>
> *I bring all my restless thoughts and fears to silence before your majesty. Reign in my heart, O King of the ages. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

DAY 6

Yet I Will Rejoice!

SCRIPTURE

Habakkuk 3:1–19

[1] A prayer of Habakkuk the prophet, according to *shigionot*.

[2] LORD, I have heard the report of you;
I fear, LORD, your work.
In the midst of the years, bring it to life;
in the midst of the years, make it known.
In turmoil, remember compassion.
[3] God came from Teman,
the Holy One from Mount Paran.
Sela
His splendour covered the heavens,
and the earth was full of his praise.
[4] His brightness was like the light;
rays broke from his hand,
and there his power was veiled.
[5] Before him went pestilence,
and plague came forth at his feet.
[6] He stood and measured the earth;
he looked and made the nations start.
The everlasting mountains were shattered,
the ancient hills sank low;
the ancient ways are his.
[7] I saw the tents of Cushan under calamity;
the tent curtains of the land of Midian trembled.
[8] Was it against the rivers that the LORD burned?
Was your anger against the rivers,
or your rage against the sea,
when you rode on your horses,
your chariots of salvation?
[9] Your bow was laid bare, utterly bare;
sworn were the rods – a word.
Sela
You split the earth into rivers.
[10] The mountains saw you and writhed;

a torrent of water passed over.
The deep gave its voice;
it lifted its hands on high.
11 Sun and moon stood still in their dwelling
at the light of your arrows as they sped,
at the brightness of the flash of your spear.
12 In fury you marched through the earth;
in anger you threshed the nations.
13 You went out for the salvation of your people,
for the salvation of your anointed.
You crushed the head of the house of the wicked,
laying bare the foundation up to the neck.
Sela
14 With his own rods you pierced the head of his warriors,
who stormed out to scatter me;
their exulting was as if to devour
the poor in a hiding place.
15 You trod the sea with your horses,
the surging of many waters.
16 I heard, and my insides trembled;
at the sound my lips quivered.
Rot entered my bones,
and where I stand I tremble.
Yet I will wait quietly for the day of distress
to come up against the people who invade us.
17 Though the fig tree does not blossom
and there is no fruit on the vines,
though the olive crop fails
and the terraced fields yield no food,
though the flock is cut off from the pen
and there are no cattle in the stalls –
18 yet I will exult in the LORD,
I will rejoice in the God of my salvation.
19 The LORD, the Lord, is my strength;
he makes my feet like those of the deer

and lets me tread on my high places.
For the choir director, on my stringed instruments.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we stand on the summit of Habakkuk's remarkable spiritual journey – and at the end of our six days together in this book. Chapter 1 began with a painful, raw question mark in the dark ("*How long, LORD, shall I cry for help, and you do not hear?*", 1:2). Chapter 2 took us into the stillness of the guard post, where God's promises of justice and faith were written down. Now, in chapter 3, everything flows into an exclamation mark of worship!

As literature, this last chapter is a liturgical psalm – complete with musical directions at the beginning ("*according to shigionot*") and at the end ("*For the choir director, on my stringed instruments*"), as well as three occurrences of the word ***Sela*** (verses 3, 9, 13). The exact meaning of *Sela* is uncertain; it probably marks a musical pause or interlude, a moment for reverent reflection. This suggests that Habakkuk's personal crisis of faith was worked into a shared song for worship, so that the whole covenant people could be strengthened by it in the time of the coming Babylonian exile.

In verses 3–15 we see a breathtaking **theophany** (an appearance of God). Habakkuk looks back over Israel's history of salvation. He probably calls to mind the events of the exodus from Egypt (the passage through the sea, vv. 8 and 15), the making of the covenant at Sinai, with God coming from the southern desert regions of Teman and Paran (v. 3; compare Deuteronomy 33:2), and – v. 11 recalls Joshua 10:12–13 – the victories under Joshua when sun and moon stood still. He reminds himself that the God who crushed the forces of nature and the world powers in the past to save his people is exactly the same God who holds the future in his hand.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **According to shigionot (*shigionot* – שִׁגְיֹנוֹת):** In verse 1 this musical term (found only here and in the heading of Psalm 7) may refer to a song with a fast, passionate and changing rhythm – a deeply emotional ode that binds trembling and ecstasy together. Its exact meaning, however, is uncertain.
- **Bring it to life (*chayyehu* – חַיֵּיהוּ) and compassion (*rachem* – רַחֵם):** In verse 2 Habakkuk prays: "*In the midst of the years, bring it to life*" (*chayyehu* – make alive, preserve, raise up) and "*In turmoil, remember compassion*" (*rachem* – deep, motherly tenderness that wells up from within; related to *rechem*, "womb"). The word *rogez*, "turmoil", is often understood as God's wrath; the same root returns in verse 16, where the prophet himself "trembles". He no longer asks God to take away the Babylonian chastisement; he asks that God's grace will keep his people alive *through* the judgement.
- **Though … yet (*ki … wa'ani* – כִּי … וְאֲנִי):** The hinge of verses 17–18 lies in the contrast between "though" and "yet" (literally: "*And I – in the* LORD *I will exult*").
- **Exult (*'alaz* – אֶעְלוֹזָה) and rejoice (*gil* – אָגִילָה):** In verse 18 the prophet uses two powerful verbs of joy. *'Alaz* means to triumph, to be exuberantly glad, and *gil* is to shout aloud for joy; some link it with a root meaning "to go round in a circle" – like someone dancing with delight. This is not a stoic, teeth-gritting acceptance of his lot; it is active, radiant joy in God himself! Notice the contrast: the enemy's "exulting" (*'alitsut*, v. 14) and the Chaldean "rejoicing" over his catch (1:15) are outdone here by the prophet's rejoicing in his God.
- **The God of my salvation (*Elohei yish'i* – אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׁעִי):* *The word for "salvation" is* yesha', *from the same root as the names* *Joshua / Yeshua (Jesus)** – "the LORD is salvation". Habakkuk literally rejoices in the God who is his Saviour.

- **Deer (*ayyalot* – אַיָּלוֹת) and high places (*bamotai* – בָּמוֹתַי):** In verse 19 God makes his feet *"like those of the deer"* – literally the does, the female deer, which climb steep, dangerous rock ledges with astonishing sureness, without slipping.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Spiritual remembering is the fuel for future hope:** When the future looks dark, the believer looks back at God's saving acts in the past (verses 3–15). For us today this means looking back to the cross and the empty tomb of Christ. If God has already defeated our greatest enemy (sin and death), he will carry us through our present storms as well.
2. **True faith does not switch off fear, but takes it captive in peace:** See how honest verse 16 is: Habakkuk's insides tremble, his lips quiver, and he trembles where he stands at the thought of the approaching war. To believe does not mean you are made of stone and feel no human fear; it means that in the middle of your trembling you choose: *"Yet I will wait quietly for the day of distress"*.
3. **The total collapse of earthly security (verse 17):** The six things listed in verse 17 represent the whole ancient farming economy, from small luxuries to bare survival: fig trees (sweetness/luxury), vines (joy/wine), olives (cooking oil and lamps), terraced fields (daily bread), the flock (wool and milk) and cattle (ploughing power and capital). It describes a total economic collapse.
4. **Unconditional worship rests on who God is, not on what God gives:** When all six pillars of earthly prosperity in verse 17 fall away, the one indestructible Pillar of verse 18 remains standing: **the LORD, the God of my salvation.** If your joy is built on your health, your wallet or your circumstances, any storm can steal it. If your joy is anchored in God, it is untouchable.

Living It Out

Habakkuk 3:17–19 is one of the most liberating passages in the whole of Scripture, precisely because it confronts us with our unspoken "contracts" with God. We often live with a conditional faith: *"Lord, I will trust you and be happy* ***as long as*** *my children are safe,* ***as long as*** *the medical tests come back clear,* ***as long as*** *my business grows, and* ***as long as*** *my dreams come true."*

But what happens when the fig tree does not blossom and the pens stand empty? What happens when the bad news does come, when the economy tightens, or when a prayer is not answered the way we had hoped? For many people, faith collapses along with their circumstances. Habakkuk shows us what mature, refined faith looks like. Note this: between chapter 1 and chapter 3 Habakkuk's outward circumstances **did not improve at all** – on the contrary, the Babylonian invasion was closer than ever! What had changed was Habakkuk's inner life.

He moved from focusing on the *problem* to focusing on the *Person* of God. That is why, with a trembling body (v. 16) but an unconquerable spirit (v. 18), he can look out over the ruins of his world and cry: **"Yet!"** And instead of the crisis trampling him, the LORD turns the sharp, dangerous rocks of his trial into "high places" on which he can stand with the nimble feet of a deer.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If you had to write your own "verse 17" in today's terms, how would it sound? (*"Though my savings run out, though this relationship is not restored, though my health …"*) Have you laid those fears out one by one before God and spoken your "Yet I will rejoice" over them?
- Look at Habakkuk's physical vulnerability in verse 16 (quivering lips, a body that trembles). Do you sometimes feel guilty for experiencing human anxiety or stress, as if it meant you had no faith? How does it en-

courage you to see that Habakkuk's trembling and his quiet trust existed side by side?

- In verse 2 Habakkuk prays: "*In the midst of the years, bring it to life*". Where in your own spiritual life, your family or your church do you need God to bring new life and compassion today, in the middle of a dry season?

Prayer

> *Mighty Lord, God of history and God of my salvation, with deep awe I come today to the end of this journey through Habakkuk. When I heard of your power and your righteous ways, my heart too has sometimes trembled, for you are high and exalted far above my small human understanding.*
>
> *Lord, today I plead with your prophet: bring your work to life in the midst of our years, and in turmoil remember your deep, motherly compassion! Today I lay all my conditions down at your feet. Forgive me that I have so often thanked you only for the fruit on the tree and the cattle in the stall, instead of finding my joy in you yourself.*
>
> *Today I declare over my life, over my fears and over my uncertain future: though every earthly prop falls away and every harvest fails, yet I will exult in the* LORD*! I will rejoice in Jesus Christ, the God of my salvation. Be my strength today. Make my weary feet like those of the deer, and let me tread the steep high places of this life in your victory. To you belongs all praise, for ever. Amen.*

The whole book of Habakkuk

The complete text of Habakkuk in the translation used in these devotionals.

Chapter 1

[1] The oracle that Habakkuk the prophet saw.

[2] How long, LORD, shall I cry for help,
and you do not hear?
I cry out to you, "Violence!"
and you do not save.
[3] Why do you make me see wickedness,
and why do you look on misery?
Destruction and violence are before me;
there is strife, and contention rises up.
[4] Therefore instruction grows numb,
and justice never comes forth.
For the wicked surrounds the righteous;
therefore justice comes forth twisted.
[5] See among the nations, and look;
be astonished – be astounded!
For I am doing a work in your days
that you would not believe if it were told.
[6] For look, I am raising up the Chaldeans,
that bitter and impetuous nation,
who march across the breadth of the earth
to take possession of dwellings that are not their own.
[7] Terrible and dreadful is he;
from himself come forth his justice and his dignity.
[8] His horses are swifter than leopards
and fiercer than wolves at evening.
His horsemen gallop on,
his horsemen come from far away;
they fly like a vulture that hurries to devour.
[9] All of them come for violence;

the set of their faces is forward,
and he gathers captives like sand.
10 He mocks at kings,
and rulers are a joke to him.
He laughs at every fortress;
he heaps up dust and captures it.
11 Then he sweeps on like the wind and passes by,
and he becomes guilty –
he whose strength is his god.
12 Are you not from of old, LORD,
my God, my Holy One?
We will not die.
LORD, you have appointed him for judgment;
O Rock, you have established him to reprove.
13 Your eyes are too pure to see evil,
and you cannot look on misery.
Why do you look on the treacherous
and keep silent when the wicked swallows up
one more righteous than he?
14 You make people like the fish of the sea,
like crawling things that have no ruler.
15 He brings them all up with a hook,
he drags them away in his net
and gathers them in his dragnet;
so he is glad and rejoices.
16 Therefore he sacrifices to his net
and burns incense to his dragnet,
for through them his portion is fat
and his food is rich.
17 Is he then to keep emptying his net
and go on killing nations without sparing?

Chapter 2

1 I will stand at my guard post
and take my place on the rampart;

I will watch to see what he will say to me
and what I shall answer concerning my reproof.

2 Then the LORD answered me and said:

Write down the vision
and make it plain on the tablets,
so that whoever reads it may run.
3 For the vision is still for the appointed time;
it pants toward the end, and it will not deceive.
If it lingers, wait for it,
for it will surely come; it will not delay.
4 Look, he is puffed up – his soul is not upright within him;
but the righteous will live by his faithfulness.
5 And moreover, wine is treacherous;
an arrogant man does not stay at home.
He opens his throat wide like the grave;
he is like death and is never sated.
He gathers to himself all the nations
and assembles to himself all the peoples.
6 Will not all of these take up a taunt against him,
a mocking song, riddles about him, and say:
Woe to the one who heaps up what is not his own –
how long? –
and loads himself heavy with pledges!
7 Will not those who bite you rise up suddenly,
and those who make you tremble wake up,
and you will become plunder for them?
8 Because you have plundered many nations,
all who are left of the peoples will plunder you,
because of human blood and violence to the land,
to the city and all who live in it.
9 Woe to the one who gains evil gain for his house,
to set his nest on high,
to be snatched from the grip of evil!
10 You have counselled shame for your house
by cutting off many peoples,

and you are sinning against your own life.
[11] For a stone from the wall will cry out,
and a rafter from the woodwork will answer it.
[12] Woe to the one who builds a town with blood
and founds a city on injustice!
[13] Look, is it not from the LORD of hosts
that peoples toil only for the fire
and nations weary themselves for nothing?
[14] For the earth will be filled
with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD,
as the waters cover the sea.
[15] Woe to the one who makes his neighbour drink,
mixing in your wrath and making him drunk as well,
in order to look on their nakedness!
[16] You are sated with disgrace instead of glory.
Drink, you too, and show your foreskin!
The cup in the LORD's right hand will come around to you,
and utter disgrace will come upon your glory.
[17] For the violence done to Lebanon will cover you,
and the destruction of the beasts that terrified them,
because of human blood and violence to the land,
to the city and all who live in it.
[18] What use is a carved image,
that its maker has carved it,
a cast image and a teacher of lies?
For its maker trusts in what he himself has formed
when he makes mute idols.
[19] Woe to the one who says to wood, "Wake up!"
"Awake!" to a silent stone.
Can it teach?
Look, it is overlaid with gold and silver,
and there is no breath at all inside it.
[20] But the LORD is in his holy temple –
silence before him, all the earth!

Chapter 3

[1] A prayer of Habakkuk the prophet, according to *shigionot*.

[2] LORD, I have heard the report of you;
I fear, LORD, your work.
In the midst of the years, bring it to life;
in the midst of the years, make it known.
In turmoil, remember compassion.
[3] God came from Teman,
the Holy One from Mount Paran.
Sela
His splendour covered the heavens,
and the earth was full of his praise.
[4] His brightness was like the light;
rays broke from his hand,
and there his power was veiled.
[5] Before him went pestilence,
and plague came forth at his feet.
[6] He stood and measured the earth;
he looked and made the nations start.
The everlasting mountains were shattered,
the ancient hills sank low;
the ancient ways are his.
[7] I saw the tents of Cushan under calamity;
the tent curtains of the land of Midian trembled.
[8] Was it against the rivers that the LORD burned?
Was your anger against the rivers,
or your rage against the sea,
when you rode on your horses,
your chariots of salvation?
[9] Your bow was laid bare, utterly bare;
sworn were the rods – a word.
Sela
You split the earth into rivers.
[10] The mountains saw you and writhed;
a torrent of water passed over.

The deep gave its voice;
it lifted its hands on high.
11 Sun and moon stood still in their dwelling
at the light of your arrows as they sped,
at the brightness of the flash of your spear.
12 In fury you marched through the earth;
in anger you threshed the nations.
13 You went out for the salvation of your people,
for the salvation of your anointed.
You crushed the head of the house of the wicked,
laying bare the foundation up to the neck.
Sela
14 With his own rods you pierced the head of his warriors,
who stormed out to scatter me;
their exulting was as if to devour
the poor in a hiding place.
15 You trod the sea with your horses,
the surging of many waters.
16 I heard, and my insides trembled;
at the sound my lips quivered.
Rot entered my bones,
and where I stand I tremble.
Yet I will wait quietly for the day of distress
to come up against the people who invade us.
17 Though the fig tree does not blossom
and there is no fruit on the vines,
though the olive crop fails
and the terraced fields yield no food,
though the flock is cut off from the pen
and there are no cattle in the stalls –
18 yet I will exult in the LORD,
I will rejoice in the God of my salvation.
19 The LORD, the Lord, is my strength;
he makes my feet like those of the deer
and lets me tread on my high places.

For the choir director, on my stringed instruments.